

I Saw A Fresco in a TV Show, Is It Real?

(No fun comment today)

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Religion and Society
In the Medieval World

Introduction

Yes, art was a sort-of-sought-out profession. No, it was not easy. Yes, only a few made it to patronage. No, that did not make it any better a job. Yes, it might have been equal to being a construction worker(I think so, that's what the anime I watched about the Renaissance showed it off as). And no, it was not a bunch of fanatics of philosophy and the beauty of art enjoyers with the Oscar Wilde thought of "*L'art pour l'art*" or "Art for art's sake". It was a difficult profession that most people took up to feed their families, stay off the streets and to keep clothes on their back. How do I know this (Other than the massive amounts of research done on this exact topic)? Because I gathered scraps of information from all over the world- watching a show, looking at a poster, hearing from someone else. History is collective knowledge of the world and putting these things together bit by bit has been a delight.

Also because I watched *Arte*, an animated series about a girl named... well. Arte. And her unconventional choice to become an artist. There are arguments on which artist she was based on, if the story holds any truth and so on. There are of course, always questions of legitimacy when it comes to shows that are typically meant for children. But today! Through this beautiful essay (that hopefully doesn't cross the word limit), we shall discover and discuss the accuracy of the show *Arte*, a manga (comic) of the same name by author Kei Ohkubo. So like. Buckle up, gather supplies and a lot of eggs. Preparing a tempera for a great board of art wood takes a while (and a lot of eggs).

Arte

In 16th-century Florence, we will not be finishing fancy needlepoint and waiting for the men for stability. Arte, a noblewoman, throws tradition out the window (with a cat screaming because the tradition landed on it). Arte is not like the other maidens of her time, not at all! She ditches the socialite life and convinces a grumpy(he's handsome when the sun hits him right. And from a distance) old master to take her on as an apprentice. It's not all sunshine and paintbrushes, though. As the only female artist in a world full of men working for their next meal, Arte faces more judgement than a reality TV show contestant. But with the determination of a tiny paintbrush battling a giant wall, she tackles challenges and proves her talent is not a Renaissance rip-off. It's a heartwarming story about chasing dreams, kicking down societal doors

(metaphorically, of course, Florence had nice doors), and becoming an artist in a world that is harsh to men but harsher to women.

The Renaissance

Imagine a really long time ago, before cars and computers. That's when something amazing called the Renaissance happened! It was like a big burst of creativity, kind of like a giant box of crayons being opened for the first time (Or Pandora's Box, but it was more Greco-Roman romanticism and obsession). As a race(the European race, to be honest), the rediscovery of art and literature and all things classic and beautiful was underway. Here we hear names of Michelangelo, Da Vinci, Machiavelli, Dante, Gutenberg, the Medicis, Pope Julius II and a whole lineup of men who were really really good at writing stuff and holy graffiti.

Arte's Renaissance

Arte takes place during the 16th century, the time where the Renaissance was happening in full blast ahead. It met with the age of exploration, bridged the gap between the Middle Ages and Modernity. Schools of thought had become well established and... well, lots of stuff happening. This was also the time where the centre of art moved from Italy to Rome. Arte captures this very well, throwing in bits of truth about how the shift affects the craftsmen and painters. As a show, Arte captures the truth of the times very well. We will explore how as we go ahead with this. At least I hope we can, I've got about 15 points to cover and a 2000 word limit(the truest bane of my academic career will be word limits).

How Much of Arte Is True?

Hayden White

White's Deal: White discusses the tension between historical reality and fictional representation. He suggests that history often focuses on the true, while fiction engages with the real—what is possible and imaginable. (You know, reality and real-ibility)

In "Arte": The anime portrays Arte's journey as she defies societal norms to become an artist(girl power). While fictional, her struggles resonate with the real challenges faced by women during the Renaissance. It also showcases many social realities that might not have been recorded as historical moments. One such occurrence is Arte being exposed to how prostitutes are treated by people and their employers.

Margaret King

King's Women: King talks about women and the role they play in her book "Women of the Renaissance". She highlights the roles played by women, starting with mothers, wives, widows, and so on. She also talks about women who were saints and nuns(Kindly refer to the song *Labor* by Paris Paloma).

In “Arte”: We see each of these roles come alive in the story: a mother, persuading her daughter to abide by societal structure, a wife who is dedicated and fears her husband, a widow trying to claim her right of her dowry being returned as her husband passes away. We even see one of the characters admit to Arte that he thought a woman could be either a nun or a wife, no third thing(wow, women outside traditional roles is about as offensive as a woman within traditional roles).

Observations

Through the course of the series, (as I said) I’ve observed a bunch of things that can be thought of as accurate and completely plausible because of the time period the story takes place in. The creators actually did some research and didn’t completely trash the time they were spending their lives(some of it, at least) animating. There has surely been a great amount of obsessing over the smallest details and capturing them in the best possible sense. The author did not slack on the truth behind each chapter of her story and that just makes this story all the more captivating and full of knowledge if you know where to search(In your face, Hollywood- they could learn something from the Japanese).

1. Tempera

Arte’s first challenge after being shown to her “master”’s studio is to prepare 20 boards for painting, which meant she had to face the egg tempera. Egg tempera was known to be a very popular method of preparing wooden boards for painting(though I cannot imagine how that stuff probably smelled). A famous painting that used the egg tempera base is “The Birth of Venus” by Botticelli. It had been one of the most famous methods of board preparation before oil painting became more relevant.

2. Pigments

Every studio made its own paint. Only pigments could be purchased and among them some were very expensive as compared to others. In the show, we see Leo, Arte’s master letting one of his clients know that blue paint would cost them more. We also see Arte mixing paints and doing the heavy work it takes to produce paints of any kind. Not much to say about this, except yes, this is true and not from Wikipedia.

3. Frescos

In one episode of the show, we get to see the characters work on a fresco painting. We are shown the wall being prepared, with even layers of plaster, then the transfer of the design from the head artist's sketches onto the wall and then the final coat of plaster being added onto the outlines to prepare the surface for painting. The final coat of plaster would only be applied to as much of the wall could be painted in a day. The painters then painted over the wet plaster and made sure the plaster didn't dry up before the brush could reach them.

This process, though not extensively covered in the show, is shown to us enough in spaces that we put the pieces together to gain full knowledge of how such a process might work.

4. Textile (kinda)

Venetian lace— also known as Venetian point lace is a type of delicate lace that originated in Venice. The origins of Venetian lace can be traced back to the late 16th century, during the Renaissance period. Early examples were deep, acute-angled points, each worked separately and linked together by a narrow band. You came for an essay on some anime girl and you're getting lace making techniques for free!

A thing of very short note in the show is actually the mention of Venetian lace, which Arte says is leagues above any other kind of lace. It was widely used in ruffs and collars by high society in Venice. We even see the lace being used accurately in the story. Arte also gains a lot of inspiration from these practice

5. Venice

The bustling port of Venice takes centre stage in Arte's story. Here, she encounters a rather colourfully inept mix of cultures – Ottomans, Spaniards, and countless others – an unfortunate kaleidoscope of war. Historically, 16th-century Venice reigned supreme, its influence reaching across the Mediterranean. Perfectly positioned, Venetian merchants became the go-between for the Middle East and Europe, amassing vast wealth. And now it is sinking(think Ozymandias).

6. Who Commissioned Paintings?

Arte encounters a diverse range of patrons in the show, from the wealthy merchant *Ubertino* to the enigmatic escort *Veronica*. These patrons, including the fresco master I forgot and the Venetian nobleman *Yuri*, mirror real-life figures who commissioned art for

various reasons. Historically, churches, merchants, bankers, and even escorts hired artists. Like the Medici family, patrons used art for self-promotion (looking good), trade (advertising), and prestige (showing off). The show accurately reflects these motivations, even if some patrons, like Veronica, might not be personal art enthusiasts themselves.

7. Art teachers for noble families

The Renaissance saw noble children tutored by highly educated individuals, often versed in Latin, Greek, philosophy, and the arts. These tutors, likely lesser nobles themselves, provided a well-rounded education, preparing future leaders in academics, manners, and courtly behaviour. In *Arte*, we see a similar role for the protagonist. Hired for her noble background, education, and artistic skills, she tutors Katarina, Yuri's niece. We need to also remember that common sense is very important when it comes to the understanding that “highly educated people” were probably just other nobles.

8. Artist Society's Structure

The artist's world in *Arte* reflects a strict hierarchy. Masters like Da Vinci, with their famous apprentices, exemplify this system. Studios bustled with apprentices tackling various tasks: from perfecting their craft with paint brushes to the less glamorous but essential jobs like preparing paints and hauling equipment. *Arte*'s struggle to become an apprentice highlights the additional hurdle she faces – prejudice in a male-dominated field. The anime emphasises the physical demands of these preparatory tasks, further complicating *Arte*'s journey in a world with ingrained social limitations. So you're not only the artists, but also at the bottom rung of every possible social hierarchy! Yay!

9. Art as a profession

While poverty wasn't typically a driving force for Renaissance artists, *Arte* portrays this reality alongside the more common scenario. Historically, artists came from various social backgrounds, often starting young and following in their fathers' footsteps. Gifted boys might be sent to renowned artists' workshops. The show captures these elements. Additionally, guilds, or "justice preachers" (*heavy emphasis on the air quotes*) depicted, offered training, camaraderie, and income regulation, fostering innovation. However, *Arte* delves deeper, showcasing characters like Leo, who uses art not just for passion but

for survival, mirroring the plight of some artists. The anime also depicts the guild's role in regulating jobs and maintaining a sense of community.

10. Study of Anatomy

During the Renaissance, the study of anatomy was indeed a complex issue. The Council of Tours in 1163 led to the Church's formulation of a prohibition against human dissections. This was in hopes of curtailing the practice of dismembering and boiling the remains of Crusaders killed in battle before their shipment home. I mean, can you blame them? Did you see how many men faint at the sight of blood?

Despite these restrictions, Renaissance artists became anatomists by necessity, as they attempted to refine a more lifelike, sculptural portrayal of the human figure. Artists like Antonio Pollaiuolo, Leonardo da Vinci, and Michelangelo are known to have undertaken detailed anatomical dissections at various points in their long careers. Did Da Vinci really eat everything he tried to dissect? Stay tuned to find out (I am not answering this question, I've already gone way past word limits)!

In the show on the other hand, while dissections were treated as a secretive affair, they did not make it into an illegal act. They did however make it seem utterly blasphemous that a *woman* had to see a dissection(though Arte took it better than the men with fainting spells).

Conclusion

So, is Arte historically accurate? Maybe not as much as a documentary on paint drying, but it's a delightful exploration of artistic practices.

Can we study history through fiction? Maybe we can use it like we use the bibliography at the end of a Wikipedia article because we don't trust the article itself, but the references are *great*.

There is surely a lot to be learned about the past through more easily digestible sources than fat books and JSTOR articles that are hard to access. Media is a great place to start and understand complex issues via simpler methods.

But of course, don't forget to actually use a secret brain ingredient called common sense and believe everything you see(also the opposite. Its not false because a show talked about it). It's tempting. I know. But you *cannot* Google "paintings by Leo from the Renaissance" looking for Arte's master. You *will* find art for the zodiac sign and the movie Leo by Vijay(No, I did not

Google it because I thought Leo was real. I did it with pure academic dedication to make this one passage funnier).

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